

I CAN DO HARD THINGS

A Growth Mindset Workbook for Kids (Ages 7-12)

12 Chapters * True Stories * Science * Activities * 30 Journal Prompts

By Daniel Tesfamariam

I CAN DO HARD THINGS: A Growth Mindset Workbook

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YOUR BRAIN CAN GROW!

What if I told you that your brain is like a muscle? That every time you try something hard, practice a new skill, or even make a mistake, your brain is literally getting STRONGER? That's not just motivation talk - it's science! This book will show you how to develop a GROWTH MINDSET: the belief that you can improve at anything through effort, strategies, and help from others. Ready to discover your unlimited potential?

CHAPTER 1

Fixed vs Growth Mindset

There are two ways to think about your abilities. A FIXED mindset says: 'I'm either smart or I'm not. I can either do it or I can't.' A GROWTH mindset says: 'I can get smarter with effort. I can't do it YET, but I will if I keep trying.' People with growth mindsets learn faster, handle challenges better, and achieve more - because they believe effort leads to improvement!

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

Thomas Edison failed 1,000 times before inventing the light bulb. He said: 'I didn't fail. I found 1,000 ways that don't work.' That's growth mindset!

CHAPTER 1: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "I'm bad at math -> I'm still learning math"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "I can't do this -> I can't do this YET"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "This is too hard -> This will take more effort"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"I can learn anything I put my mind to."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

This week: Catch yourself saying 'I can't' and add 'YET' every time.

CHAPTER 2

The Power of YET

One tiny word can change everything: YET. 'I can't ride a bike' becomes 'I can't ride a bike YET.' 'I don't understand fractions' becomes 'I don't understand fractions YET.' The word YET means you're on a journey. You haven't arrived, but you're moving forward. Every expert started as a beginner who kept going. Add YET to every negative thought and watch how it transforms your perspective.

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

A baby doesn't give up after falling 100 times while learning to walk. They don't say 'I guess I'm just not a walker.' They get up and try again. That's the power of YET.

CHAPTER 2: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "I don't understand science"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "I'm not good at sports"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "I can't make friends easily"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"I haven't mastered this YET, and that's okay."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Add YET to every negative statement for an entire day. Notice the shift.

CHAPTER 3

Learning from Mistakes

Mistakes are not proof that you're failing - they're proof that you're TRYING. Every mistake teaches you something valuable. Scientists call mistakes 'data.' Athletes call missed shots 'practice.' Musicians call wrong notes 'learning.' The only real mistake is being too afraid to try at all. Embrace your mistakes, study them, and use them as stepping stones to success.

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

Michael Jordan was cut from his high school basketball team. J.K. Rowling's Harry Potter was rejected by 12 publishers. Oprah was fired from her first TV job. They all learned from their mistakes.

CHAPTER 3: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "Write about a time a mistake taught you something valuable"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Interview an adult about their biggest mistake and what they learned"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Start a 'Mistake Journal' - record mistakes and lessons weekly"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"Mistakes help me grow and learn."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Make ONE mistake on purpose today. Notice: the world didn't end!

CHAPTER 4

Effort Beats Talent

Natural talent is great, but effort always wins in the long run. Research shows that people who believe in effort outperform those who rely on talent alone. Why? Because talented people often avoid challenges (they might fail and look bad). But effort-focused people embrace challenges (that's how they grow). The tortoise really does beat the hare!

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

Studies show that praising kids for effort ('You worked so hard!') leads to better outcomes than praising talent ('You're so smart!'). Effort praise motivates trying harder.

CHAPTER 4: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "Think of something you improved at through practice"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Set a goal that requires effort, not just talent"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Track your practice hours this week on something challenging"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"My effort determines my success."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Practice one skill for 30 minutes. Notice improvement vs day 1.

CHAPTER 5

Embracing Challenges

Challenges are like weights at the gym - they make you stronger! When something feels difficult, your brain is literally growing new connections. Easy things don't teach you much. Hard things build new neural pathways. Next time you face something challenging, try saying: 'My brain is growing right now!' instead of 'This is too hard.' Challenges are where all the growth happens.

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

Your brain is like a muscle. Just like lifting weights makes muscles bigger, solving hard problems makes your brain form new connections. No challenge = no growth.

CHAPTER 5: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "List 3 challenges you're currently facing"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Pick one and break it into smaller, manageable steps"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Celebrate after completing each step!"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"Challenges make me stronger."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Do something outside your comfort zone today. Report what you learned.

CHAPTER 6

Dealing with Failure

Failure is not the opposite of success - it's PART of success. Every successful person has a long list of failures. The difference is they didn't let failure stop them. They failed FORWARD - using each failure as a lesson and stepping stone. How you respond to failure defines your future. Will you give up or get up?

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

FAIL = First Attempt In Learning. Reframe failure as a teacher, not a judge. Ask: 'What can I learn?' not 'What's wrong with me?'

CHAPTER 6: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "Write about your biggest failure - what did it teach you?"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Create a 'failure resume' of famous people's failures"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Next time you fail, write 3 things you learned from it"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"Failure is just feedback for improvement."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Intentionally try something hard. When you fail, journal what you learned.

CHAPTER 7

The Brain Is a Muscle

Neuroscience proves that your brain physically changes when you learn! Every time you practice something hard, neurons in your brain make new connections. The more you practice, the stronger these connections get. This is called neuroplasticity. You are literally BUILDING your brain every time you study, practice, or learn something new. Your intelligence is not fixed!

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

When you struggle with something, your brain releases a chemical that helps neurons connect. That means struggling is actually your brain's BEST learning state!

CHAPTER 7: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "Draw your brain growing new connections"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Research: what does 'neurons that fire together wire together' mean?"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Choose one skill and practice it 15 minutes daily for a week"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"My brain grows stronger every day."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Learn one new fact about the brain today. Share it with someone.

CHAPTER 8

Famous People Who Failed First

Walt Disney was fired for 'lacking imagination.' Einstein couldn't speak until age 4. Beethoven's music teacher said he was 'hopeless.' Steven Spielberg was rejected from film school 3 times. Each of these people could have given up. But they had growth mindsets. They believed they could improve. And they did - changing the world in the process.

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

The pattern: Try -> Fail -> Learn -> Try differently -> Fail better -> Learn more -> Eventually SUCCEED. There are no shortcuts.

CHAPTER 8: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "Research 3 more famous people who overcame failure"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Write a 'failure to success' story about yourself"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Create a motivational poster with a growth mindset quote"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"If they can do it, I can learn to do it too."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Research one famous failure story and present it to your family.

CHAPTER 9

Positive Self-Talk

The voice in your head matters more than any voice outside. If you constantly tell yourself 'I'm stupid' or 'I can't do this,' your brain believes it. But if you tell yourself 'I'm learning' and 'I can figure this out,' your brain rises to meet that belief. You talk to yourself all day long - make sure it's helpful, encouraging talk!

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

Replace: 'I'm not smart enough' with 'I haven't learned this yet.' Replace: 'Everyone is better than me' with 'Everyone is on their own journey.'

CHAPTER 9: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "Write 5 negative thoughts you often have, then rewrite each positively"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Put positive sticky notes on your mirror"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Practice saying 'I can do hard things' before challenges"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"I choose encouraging thoughts."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Write 10 positive self-talk phrases and read them every morning.

CHAPTER 10

Setting Stretch Goals

A stretch goal pushes you just beyond your comfort zone. Not so easy it's boring, not so hard you give up - just challenging enough to make you grow. Break big goals into smaller milestones. Celebrate progress, not just completion. And remember: the person who aims for the moon might land among the stars. Dream big, then plan small steps.

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

SMART goals: Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound. 'I'll read more' is vague. 'I'll read 20 pages daily for 30 days' is SMART.

CHAPTER 10: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "Set 3 stretch goals: easy, medium, and hard"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Break your hard goal into 5 smaller steps"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Create a visual tracker for your goals"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"I set goals and work toward them daily."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Set a stretch goal for this week and track daily progress.

CHAPTER 11

Celebrating Growth (Not Just Success)

Growth mindset means celebrating the PROCESS, not just the result. Did you try something scary? Celebrate! Did you practice even when it was boring? Celebrate! Did you ask for help? Celebrate! Did you keep going after failure? Celebrate! Growth happens in the trying, not just the achieving. Notice and appreciate your effort, persistence, and courage.

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

Instead of 'I got an A!' try 'I studied really hard and it paid off!' The first celebrates luck. The second celebrates effort you can repeat.

CHAPTER 11: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

REFRAME IT! (Fixed -> Growth)

Fixed: "List 5 growth moments from this month (even small ones!)"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Write a letter to yourself celebrating your effort"

Growth: _____

Fixed: "Create a 'Growth Wins' jar - add a note whenever you grow"

Growth: _____

TODAY'S AFFIRMATION:

"I celebrate my effort, not just results."

Say it 3 times. Write it on a sticky note. Believe it!

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Notice 3 times you grew today (even tiny growth counts!).

CHAPTER 12

My Growth Mindset Journal

This final chapter is YOUR space. Use these 30 daily prompts to build your growth mindset muscle every single day. Journaling helps your brain process experiences, find patterns, and strengthen positive thinking pathways. Just 5 minutes a day can transform how you think about challenges, effort, and your own potential. You've got this!

INSPIRING TRUE STORY:

Consistency is key. Even on days when you don't feel like writing, just jot one sentence. Small daily actions create massive long-term change.

CHAPTER 12: GROWTH ACTIVITIES

THIS WEEK'S CHALLENGE:

Complete your first journal entry! Then do one every day this week.

30-DAY GROWTH MINDSET JOURNAL

Day 1: What is one thing I'm proud of learning recently?

Day 2: Describe a time I didn't give up when something was hard.

Day 3: What mistake did I make today? What did it teach me?

Day 4: Name 3 things I'm better at now than I was a year ago.

Day 5: What challenge am I facing? How can I break it into steps?

Day 6: Who inspires me? What growth mindset traits do they have?

Day 7: What would I attempt if I knew I couldn't fail?

Day 8: How did I show effort today? Rate my effort 1-10.

Day 9: Write about something I used to find hard that is now easy.

Day 10: What's one thing I want to improve at? What's my plan?

30-DAY JOURNAL (continued)

Day 11: Describe a failure that led to something good.

Day 12: What positive self-talk did I use today?

Day 13: What's outside my comfort zone? Am I willing to try?

Day 14: List 5 of my strengths. How can I use them today?

Day 15: What did I learn from feedback I received?

Day 16: How did I help someone else grow today?

Day 17: What's a new strategy I tried when stuck?

Day 18: Rate my growth mindset today: 1-10. Why that rating?

Day 19: What would 'future me' tell 'today me' about this challenge?

Day 20: Describe a moment I chose courage over comfort.

30-DAY JOURNAL (continued)

Day 21: What am I grateful I can learn?

Day 22: How did struggle lead to growth for me this week?

Day 23: What's one limiting belief I'm ready to let go of?

Day 24: Write a letter of encouragement to yourself.

Day 25: What growth do I want to celebrate?

Day 26: How will I practice growth mindset tomorrow?

Day 27: What did trying hard feel like today?

Day 28: Name someone who believes in me. How does that feel?

Day 29: What's my biggest growth mindset win this month?

Day 30: Write your growth mindset declaration for the future!

GROWTH MINDSET CHAMPION CERTIFICATE

Awarded to:

For completing this entire book!

Date: _____

Author: Daniel Tesfamariam

Date. _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Date. _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Date. _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

[illegible]

Date. _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

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How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

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Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

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Date: _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

[illegible]

Date. _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

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Date. _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

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Date. _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

[illegible]

Date: _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Date. _____

Today I learned:

How I will use this:

My goal for tomorrow:

Free writing space:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue or grey ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

CHALLENGE:

Think of 3 new ideas related to this topic and explain each one.

My Work:

[illegible]

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

CHALLENGE:

Create a mind map connecting everything you learned.

My Work:

[illegible]

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

CHALLENGE:

Write a letter explaining this topic to a younger child.

My Work:

[illegible]

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

CHALLENGE:

List 10 questions you still have about this topic.

My Work:

[illegible]

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

CHALLENGE:

Draw a comic strip showing what you learned in action.

My Work:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

[illegible]

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

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CHALLENGE:

Write a short story using ideas from this chapter.

My Work:

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Self-rating (circle): AMAZING / GOOD / NEEDS MORE WORK

CREATIVE SPACE: GROWTH MINDSET

Draw what you learned today

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, occupying the central portion of the page. It is intended for a student to draw, write, or brainstorm based on their learning.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: GROWTH MINDSET

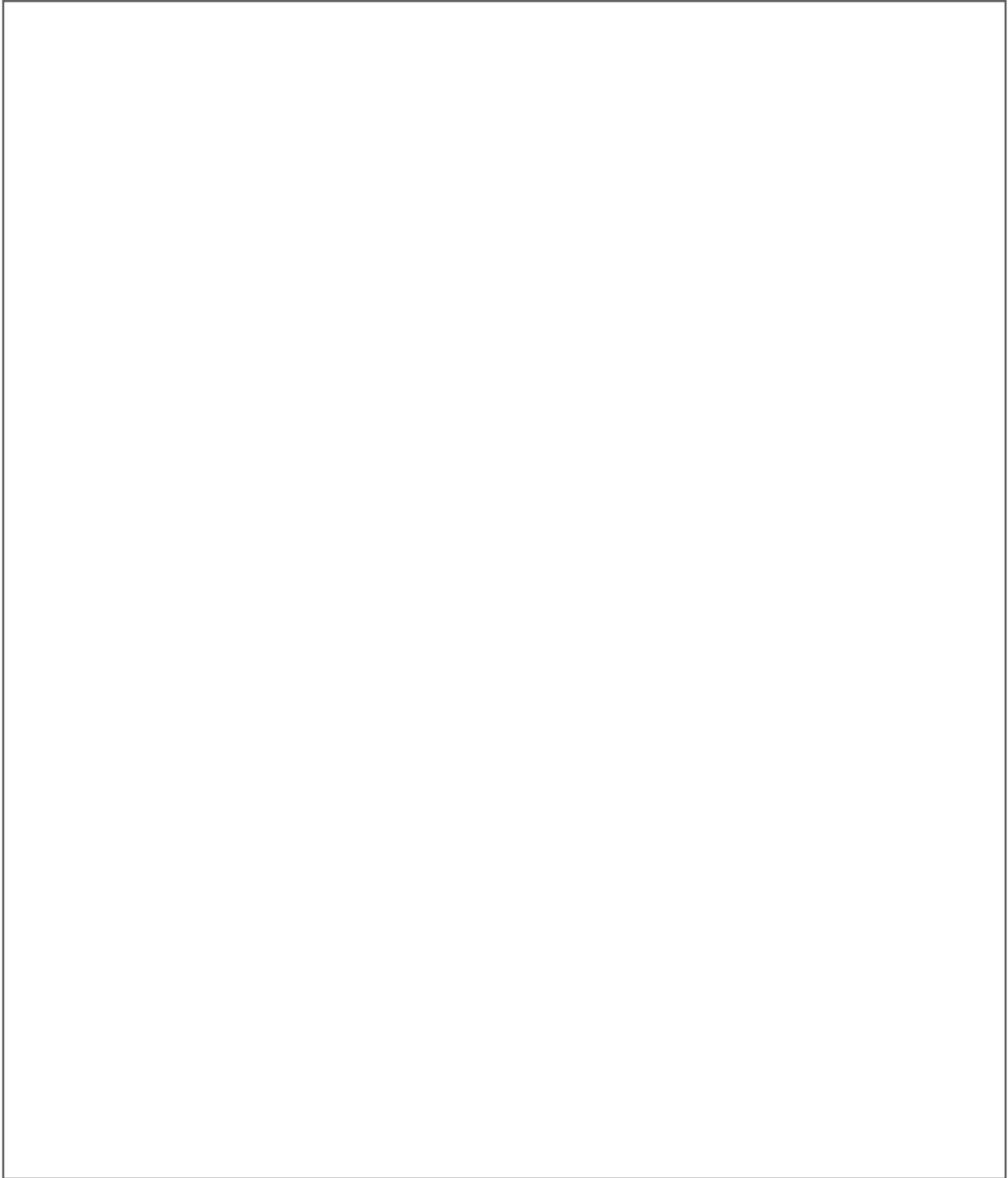
Illustrate your favorite concept

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, occupying the central portion of the page. It is intended for a user to draw, write, or brainstorm within it.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: GROWTH MINDSET

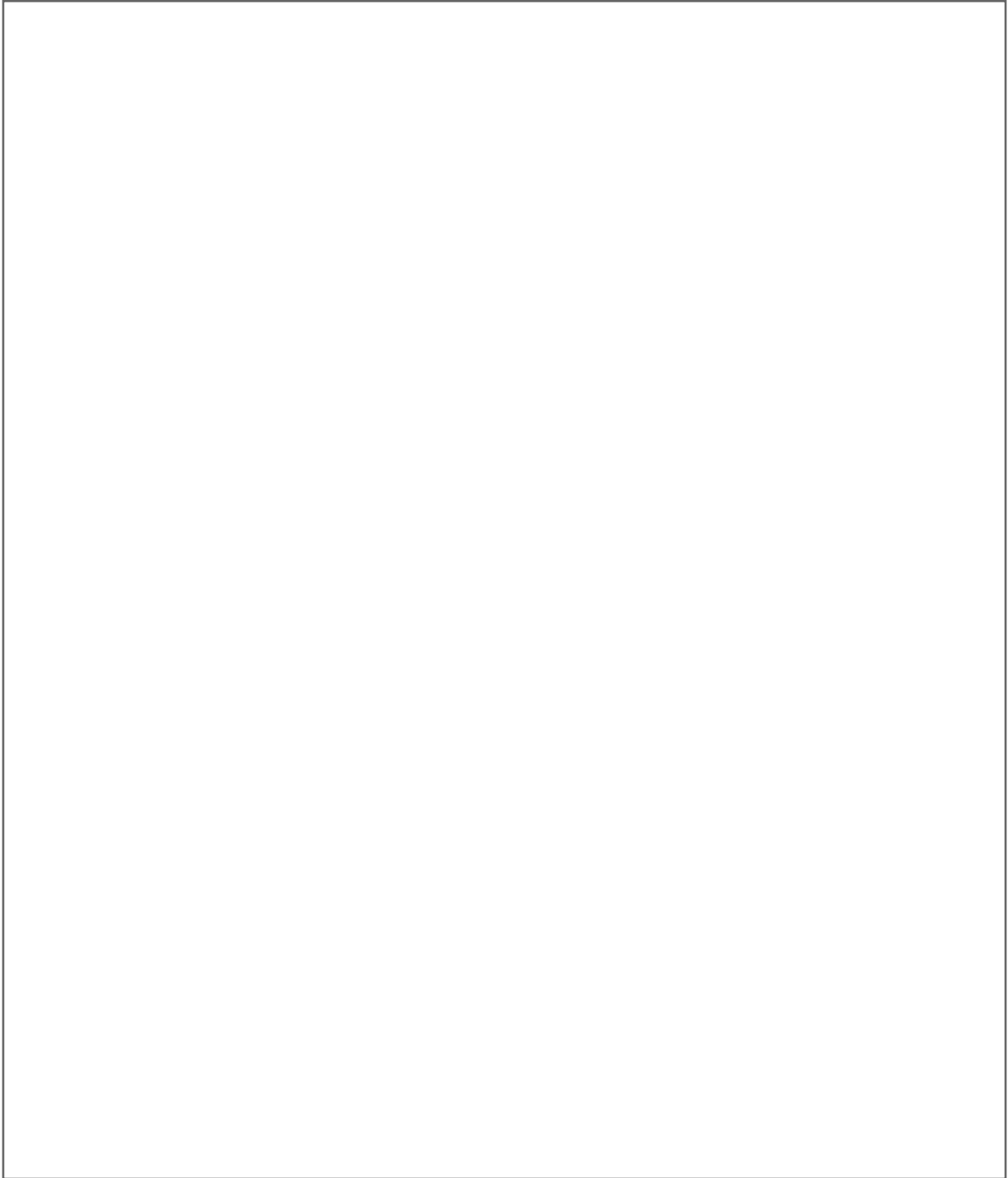
Create a visual summary of this chapter

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, intended for a visual summary, drawing, or brainstorming activity.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: GROWTH MINDSET

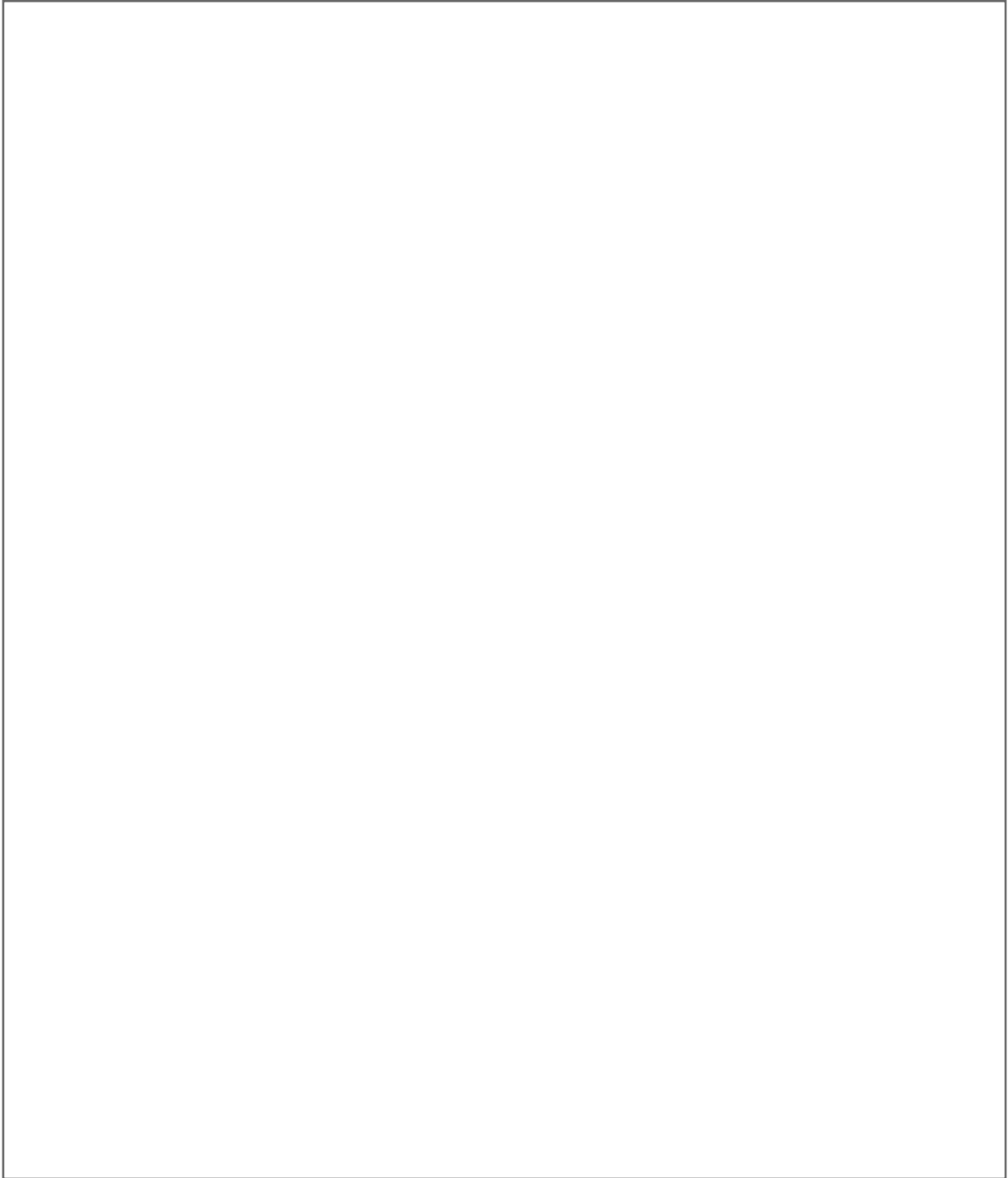
Draw yourself using this knowledge

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, intended for drawing, writing, or brainstorming. It occupies the central portion of the page, below the introductory text and above the concluding text.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: GROWTH MINDSET

Design a symbol that represents this topic

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, intended for a student to draw a symbol or write their thoughts related to the topic of Growth Mindset.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: GROWTH MINDSET

Sketch your goals

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, occupying the central portion of the page. It is intended for sketching goals, as indicated by the text above it.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

CREATIVE SPACE: GROWTH MINDSET

Illustrate a story from this book

A large, empty rectangular box with a thin black border, occupying the central portion of the page. It is intended for a student to draw, write, or brainstorm a story from the book 'Creative Space: Growth Mindset'.

Use this space for drawing, writing, or brainstorming!

[illegible]

This image shows a full page of blank, lined paper. It features approximately 20 evenly spaced horizontal grey lines across the entire width of the page, providing a guide for writing. The background is a solid off-white color. There are no margins, text, or other markings present.

This image shows a full page of blank, lined paper. It features approximately 20 evenly spaced horizontal grey lines across the entire width of the page, providing a guide for writing. The background is a solid off-white color. There are no margins, text, or other markings present.

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[illegible]